decline in the south-west monsoon that affected the Harappan Civilisation also made itself felt in the south-western corner of Afghanistan. The rich pasturelands became incapable of sustaining large herds and flocks, so the local pastoralists moved on. Some chose to migrate eastwards with their horses, chariots and livestock – and as they moved so the sacred river of their fathers moved with them, but now just as a pious memory, to be replanted in the upper Punjab along the course of what was already a largely but not yet entirely dried-up river-bed. But soon even this substitute Saraswati River became incapable of nurturing their cattle and crops, so that its decline had to be accounted for in pious fables. The river goddess was then transformed into the much-loved Hindu deity that she is today, the wife of Lord Brahma, goddess of wisdom and patron of knowledge, learning, music and the arts.